Countries fall short on money to protect nature before big U.N. meeting

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Nearly 200 countries promised to raise huge amounts of money to protect the world's oceans, forests, rivers and wildlife. So far, they have raised far less than they planned.

That gap will be a main topic at a United Nations meeting on **biodiversity**, called COP17, which begins Monday in Yerevan, Armenia, and is scheduled to end October 30. **Biodiversity** means the variety of plants and animals living on Earth. The countries will check their progress on 23 goals they agreed to in Montreal in 2022. The United States is not part of this **treaty**.

Under that deal, countries promised to raise $200 billion a year for nature by 2030. Data from the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development shows they raised between $75 billion and $92 billion each year from 2023 to 2025, less than half the goal. A U.N. report released Thursday found that fewer than half of the **targets** are on track.

"We're not moving fast enough," said Astrid Schomaker, who leads the **treaty**'s office.

One goal is going better. Countries were on track to give $20 billion a year to poorer countries by 2025, and $19 billion had been raised in 2024. However, a drop in **foreign aid** raises questions about whether that will continue.

There are other signs of progress. Countries have announced more than 5,000 projects connected to the **treaty**. The Philippines created an ocean area where catching rays and sharks is not allowed, and Argentina created a new national park in 2024. On Friday, a 17-nation group launched an effort to help **threatened species** recover. Nine private organizations also announced plans to spend $500 million over five years to prevent **extinctions**.

Word Treasure

biodiversity -- Biodiversity is the variety of all the plants and animals living in a place or on Earth.

treaty -- A treaty is a formal agreement between countries.

targets -- Targets are specific goals that people agree to try to reach.

foreign aid -- Foreign aid is money or help that one country gives to another country.

extinctions -- Extinctions happen when a type of plant or animal dies out completely.

threatened species -- Threatened species are kinds of plants or animals at risk of disappearing.

Background you need

Biodiversity is the variety of life on Earth, from tiny insects to huge forests, and healthy ecosystems give people food, clean water and air.

Many countries signed a United Nations treaty that commits them to protect nature, and they agreed on shared goals in Montreal in 2022.

The COP17 meeting is a regular gathering where these countries check how they are doing and decide what to do next.

Protecting land and oceans costs money for things like parks, scientists and rangers, which is why funding is a central issue.

Break it down

LEAD: Countries have raised far less money than they promised to protect nature.
KEY EVENT: The U.N. biodiversity meeting COP17
+- WHERE: Yerevan, Armenia
+- WHEN: Begins Monday and is scheduled to end October 30
EVIDENCE: $75 billion to $92 billion a year raised from 2023 to 2025, versus a $200 billion goal by 2030; fewer than half of targets on track
QUOTE: Astrid Schomaker says, "We're not moving fast enough"
PROGRESS: Aid to poorer countries near its goal; more than 5,000 projects; new protected areas; a 17-nation group and $500 million from private organizations
OPEN QUESTION: Whether foreign aid cuts will slow progress

Why it matters

Plants and animals support the food, water and air people rely on, so whether countries pay for protecting nature affects the whole planet's future.

Test what you remember

1. Where is the COP17 biodiversity meeting being held?

- (A) New York City
- (B) Yerevan, Armenia
- (C) Manila, Philippines
- (D) Montreal, Canada

2. How much money did countries promise to raise each year for nature by 2030?

- (A) $200 billion
- (B) $92 billion
- (C) $20 billion
- (D) $500 million

3. How much did countries actually raise each year from 2023 to 2025?

- (A) More than $200 billion
- (B) Nothing at all
- (C) About $19 million
- (D) Between $75 billion and $92 billion

4. What did a U.N. report released Thursday find?

- (A) Fewer than half of the targets are on track
- (B) All targets are complete
- (C) The United States joined the treaty
- (D) The treaty has ended

5. Which goal is going better than the others?

- (A) Protecting the Moon
- (B) Ending all fishing
- (C) Planting trees in Armenia
- (D) Money for poorer countries

6. What did the Philippines create?

- (A) A new treaty office
- (B) A 17-nation group
- (C) An ocean area where catching rays and sharks is not allowed
- (D) A new national park

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Astrid Schomaker, head of the treaty's office: Says countries are not moving fast enough to meet their nature goals.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):